

SJAA Ephemeris Bulletin

✱ Feb 2026

Anniversary

What were you doing a year ago? Maybe you were observing one of this month's wonderful objects, like our target of the month, M81. Maybe you were watching Super Bowl 59, and enjoying a snack of kale chips and hummus. Maybe, just maybe, you were reading the inaugural issue of this publication! The Ephemeris Bulletin turns one year old today, and my they sure do grow up quickly, don't they?

We conceived the Bulletin as a supplement to the quarterly Ephemeris publication. The Ephemeris provides a detailed update on the club's ongoing activities and major celestial events, but there was a clear gap in getting "timely" communications to our members. The Bulletin is designed to fill that gap. We aim to provide important club announcements, timely observational notes, and our full month's calendar of events through the Bulletin's single page, double-sided format. Perfect for printing out and putting on your fridge or the office corkboard.

Thank you all for the support over the last year. A very big, special thanks to Joe Fragola for tirelessly providing calendar and observing updates. I look forward to another year of Bulletins! Keep looking up!

Carl Svensson
Vice-President
Ephemeris Editor

Target of the Month - Bode's Nebula

by Carl Svensson

This February, turn your attention to the magnificent spiral galaxy M81, also known as Bode's Nebula, residing 12 million light-years away in Ursa Major. Discovered by Johann Bode in 1774, this stunning galaxy shines at magnitude 6.9, making it one of the brightest galaxies visible from northern latitudes.

Finding M81: Located just 10 degrees northwest of the Big Dipper's bowl, M81 forms a striking pair with its companion, M82 (the Cigar Galaxy), separated by only 0.5 degrees. Both fit comfortably in the same low-power eyepiece field.

What to Look For: Through binoculars, M81 appears as an elongated smudge. Small telescopes (4-6 inches) reveal its oval shape and bright core, while 8-inch or larger instruments begin to hint at the graceful spiral structure that earned it the nickname "Grand Design Spiral."

Observing Tips: Target M81 during evening hours when Ursa Major climbs high in the northeast. Dark skies greatly enhance views of the galaxy's outer envelope. Use averted vision to detect subtle details in the spiral arms.

M81's gravitational interaction with M82 triggered intense star formation in its neighbor—a cosmic dance visible through your telescope.

Magnitude	6.9
Size	21.6' x 11.3'
Object Type	Spiral Galaxy
Constellation	Ursa Major
Distance	12 Mly
Age	12 billion years



Bode's Nebula as imaged by Carl Svensson in February of 2023. Taken with LRGB filters under Bortle 8 skies for a total of almost 19 hours of exposure.

Volunteer Opportunities

There are many volunteer opportunities in SJAA! Please do not hesitate to reach out to the volunteer coordinator (volunteerchair@sjaa.net) to inquire about opportunities. Below are a few examples of programs that could use help:

Ephemeris That's right! Your local publishing house could use some help with any of the following: content, layout, graphics, archiving, and more. Unleash your inner journalist and email ephemeris@sjaa.net today!

Imaging SIG The SJAA Imaging SIG (Special Interest Group) welcomes members to give talks in our monthly imaging meetings on topics related to astro-imaging. World-class expertise not required! Example topics include: comet astrophotography, solar imaging, PixInsight skills, NINA tutorial, remote imaging, collimating telescopes, "my favorite astro gadgets", the science behind astrophotographs, "I love my mount/scope/software/...". Please don't be modest, we need you!

For past talks see our YouTube channel (@sj-astronomy7497). Please email imagingsig@sjaa.net if you're interested in presenting.

Loaner Program Our loaner program is looking for one to two more volunteers to help members check out gear and to demonstrate the set-up and usage of loaned items. The only requirement is an interest in astro gear and availability on one Sunday per month. Email loaners@sjaa.net if you are interested.

SSP The School Star Party Program is looking for more regular volunteers. We provide fun and exciting observing opportunities for schools. The ideal volunteer should have a telescope, some basic astronomy knowledge, and enjoy inspiring people. Interested parties should be available for the events and can contact ssp@sjaa.net for more information.



SJAA Feb 2026

Sunday	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday
1 Solar, Loaner, Fix-It 1:30PM  100%	2  99%	3  95%	4 Clyde Tombaugh's Birthday (1906)  90%	5 Astro 101 Public Talk 7:00PM  83%	6  75%	7 Board Meeting 6:00PM Member Recognition 8:00PM  66%
8  56%	9  47%	10 Astro 101 Beginner's Forum 7:00PM  38%	11  29%	12  21%	13 Astro 101 Public Talks 6:00PM In-Town Star Party 7:15PM  14%	14 Mendoza Ranch Member Observing 5:00PM Fritz Zwicky's Birthday (1898)  8%
15 Galileo Galilei's Birthday (1564)  3%	16 Grant Park Member Observing 5:00PM  1%	17 Imaging SIG Meeting 7:30PM  0%	18  2%	19 Nicolaus Copernicus's Birthday (1473)  6%	20  13%	21 Starry Nights Star Party 7:00PM  21%
22  31%	23  43%	24  54%	25  66%	26  77%	27  86%	28  93%
			Times and dates are subject to change. Please check sjaa.net and www.meetup.com/sj-astronomy for the latest updates.			

Meteor Shower

Dark Sky Window